WhatsApp Business API (WABA)

Requirements & Application Checklist — Meta WhatsApp Business Platform

This document summarizes everything required to apply for and set up WhatsApp Business API access through Meta, including required documents, account setup steps, and key decisions to make before applying.

1. What is WhatsApp Business API

The WhatsApp Business API (officially the **WhatsApp Business Platform**) lets a company send and receive WhatsApp messages programmatically — order updates, OTPs, customer support, and marketing messages at scale, with multiple team members/agents able to use one business number. It is different from the free WhatsApp Business App, which is meant for very small-scale, single-device use.

2. Documents & Information Required

Item	Details
Business registration proof	GST Certificate / Certificate of Incorporation / other legal registration proof
PAN Card	Business or company PAN card
Registered business address	Must exactly match the address on GST/incorporation documents
Legal business name	Must exactly match name on all submitted documents (mismatches are the #1 rejection reason)
Business website	Recommended — improves trust during Meta's verification review
Facebook Business Page	Must be linked to the same Meta Business Portfolio
Dedicated phone number	A number NOT currently active on the regular WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business App
Business display name	Must be compliant — no ALL CAPS, no promotional language, must match registered name
Use case description	Written explanation: transactional (OTP/order updates), marketing, or both

Note: A mismatch between the business name on GST/incorporation documents and the Meta Business Manager profile is the most common cause of delayed or rejected verification.

3. Step-by-Step Setup Process

1. Create a Meta Developer account
Register at developers.facebook.com using a Facebook login. Free of cost.

2. Set up a Meta Business Portfolio

Create a Business Portfolio (formerly "Business Manager") at business.facebook.com — the central hub for the WhatsApp Business Account (WABA), Pages, and assets.

3. Complete Business Verification
Submit legal business name, address, and tax ID (GST/PAN/Incorporation Certificate). Must match exactly across all documents.

4. Prepare a dedicated phone number
Number must not be active on the standard WhatsApp/WhatsApp Business App. If it is, it must be freed up (app deleted/number deregistered) before it can be linked to the API.

5. Choose a compliant display name
No ALL CAPS, no promotional phrasing; must match the registered business name.

6. Choose onboarding route: BSP or direct Cloud API
Most small/mid-size businesses onboard via a Meta-authorized Business Solution Provider (BSP) such as Wati, Gupshup, Interakt, or AiSensy, using an easy "Embedded Signup" flow. Larger businesses with a technical/dev team can integrate directly with Meta's Cloud API.

7. Define the use case
Clearly state whether messaging will be transactional (OTP, order/delivery updates), marketing, or a mix of both — required as part of the application.

8. Generate access token
Once approved, generate a System User access token (whatsapp_business_messaging + whatsapp_business_management scopes). Store securely — never in source code.

9. Set up webhook (if not using a BSP)
A secure HTTPS webhook URL is required to receive incoming messages and delivery events. Each payload is signed (HMAC-SHA256) and should be verified.

4. Key Decisions Before Applying

- **BSP vs. Direct Cloud API** — BSP is faster to set up and includes support, dashboard, and managed webhooks (usually at a markup on per-message cost). Direct Cloud API is cheaper long-term but needs an in-house developer to manage tokens, webhooks, and infrastructure.
- **Which phone number to use** — decide now, since it must be freed from the regular WhatsApp app before onboarding, which can cause downtime on that number.
- **Primary use case** — customer support, marketing broadcasts, order/OTP notifications, or a combination — this affects template approval and messaging costs.

5. Common Rejection / Delay Reasons

- Business name mismatch between GST/PAN/Incorporation documents and Meta Business Manager profile
- Phone number still active on the WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business mobile app at time of onboarding
- Display name that looks promotional, uses ALL CAPS, or doesn't match the registered business name
- Incomplete or unclear use-case description

Prepared as a reference summary based on Meta's WhatsApp Business Platform requirements (2026). For the latest official details, refer to developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp.